Cultural Debt

Tuesday, April 28, 2026 12:15 PM

BEHAVIOR AGILITY IMPACTS

Speed of Innovation	Consistency of Execution	Continuous Improvement	Employee Engagement
Behaviorally agile teams were **~3× MORE LIKELY** more likely to "strongly agree" that people speak up quickly	Top decile teams were **~6× MORE LIKELY** to suggest improvements without fear of power dynamics	Top teams were **~3× MORE LIKELY** to agree that peers "immediately correct" misuse of new approaches	

CRUCIAL CONVERSATIONS FOR BEHAVIORAL AGILITY

Speaking up: Openly point out concerns that indicate a need for innovation.

Reminding: Nudge colleagues when they default to past routines instead of improved methods.

Holding each other accountable: Offer direct and immediate correction if someone violates best practices or agreed-upon behavioral norms.

Challenging sacred cows: Follow the data irrespective of ego or habit.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

By the end of this segment, you will be able to:

1. Recognize the early warning signs that AI is not delivering before results break down
2. Identify whether the issue is technical or a breakdown in visibility, adoption, accountability, or assumptions
3. Use a simple, four-question diagnostic to assess where your AI initiatives are succeeding or falling short
4. Take immediate action to correct the highest execution gap

OPERATOR PERSPECTIVE

AI doesn't fail because the model is wrong. It fails because the work around it breaks.

- We don't see what's actually happening
- People don't trust or use the output
- No one owns whether it's working
- We assume the model reflects reality

AI exposes how your organization actually works

BEHAVIOR

SPEAK UP

3M Health Information Systems

THE DEPENDENCY EXISTED.
THE CONVERSATION DIDN'T.

- We built an ML system to automate inpatient coding. The model outputs were inconsistent, and we didn't know why.
- Clinicians were changing "forms" used to collect information in the electronic health record; revenue cycle never saw or knew these changes were happening. It wasn't important before.
- Clinical and revenue cycle had never needed to talk. AI made that silence expensive.
- Fixing it wasn't a model update. It was visibility; controls on changes and coordination between teams.

This was a visibility failure.

BEHAVIOR

THE MODEL WAS RIGHT.
THE ASSUMPTION WAS WRONG.

CHALLENGE

Air Methods

- We built the model on strong systems data with confidence from leadership.
- Area managers heard crew resistance and assumed it was change-aversion.
- They didn't test whether the model matched reality.
- When concerns didn't gain traction crews stopped pushing.
- It took just one direct conversation with a crew member to surface what we all had missed.
- The starting assumption was wrong.

This was an assumption failure.

AI EXECUTION DIAGNOSTIC™

Score your AI initiative in 60 seconds

VISIBILITY
What don't we see?

- **RED LIGHT** — Fragmented inputs, hidden dependencies
- **GREEN LIGHT** — Same inputs, shared visibility

ADOPTION
Are people using it?

- **RED LIGHT** — Workarounds, parallel workflows
- **GREEN LIGHT** — Same workflow, consistent use

ACCOUNTABILITY
Is it really working?

- **RED LIGHT** — Different date, different stories
- **GREEN LIGHT** — Same data, same story

ASSUMPTIONS
What are we assuming?

- **RED LIGHT** — Model trusted over reality
- **GREEN LIGHT** — Reality tested, assumptions exposed

SCORE 0–8
0 = Red | 1 = Mixed | 2 = Green (per dimension)

START WITH YOUR LOWEST SCORE

🔗 AI Execution Diagnostic:
1. VISIBILITY: What don't we see?
2. ADOPTION: Are people using it?
3. ACCOUNTABILITY: Is it really working?
4. ASSUMPTIONS: What are we assuming?

IF YOU SEE THIS, DO THIS

The Gap / Symptom	*Do This*
VISIBILITY GAP *Fragmented inputs, hidden dependencies*	▶ Map inputs end-to-end (who creates, who changes, who consumes) ▶ Assign ownership for each dependency—no invisible handoffs
ADOPTION GAP *Workarounds, parallel workflows*	▶ Standardize one way of working (remove optional paths) ▶ Make outputs explainable—user understand why, not just what
ACCOUNTABILITY GAP *Different data, different stories*	▶ Define one shared metric of success (visible to all stakeholders) ▶ Review results in one forum—same data, same conversation
ASSUMPTION GAP *Model trusted over reality*	▶ Test outputs in real conditions (not just system data) ▶ Create a feedback loop from frontline users—weekly, not ad hoc

AI succeeds when those conversations happen. If it fails where they don't.